

Adding forms to your Express server

Welcome to this lab activity

In this lab activity, you will explore how to add forms to your Express web application. Forms are very important for data manipulation and allow you to collect, update and verify input from users.

You will add a new page to your web application that will provide the beginnings of a 'search' capability, allowing users to search for things on your website. The page will show a form, allowing the user to enter what they are searching for. It won't actually search for anything at this point (you will do this in a future lab).

Task 1: Make a copy of your previous lab

You will start with your previous lab code.

1. Make a copy of the folder `07_dynamic_html` from your previous lab and call it `08_forms`.
2. Open the new folder in Visual Studio Code.
3. Run the code and confirm that the homepage and about page show up (refer to the previous lab if you need a reminder of how to do this).

Task 2: Add a new search page

Let's add a new page that will display a search form, allowing the user to describe what they are searching for.

4. Add a new file called `search.ejs` in the views folder.
5. Add the following contents to `search.ejs`:

```
<!doctype html>
<html>
  <head>
    <title>This is the search page title!</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <h1> This is the search page </h1>
    <form action="/search_result" method="GET">
      <input id="search_box" type="text" name="search_text">
      <input type="submit" value="OK" >
```

```
        </form>
    </body>
</html>
```

Task 3: Render the search page in response to the /search route

In the previous task, you added the search page, but you need to get it to be displayed in response to a user's request for the `/search` route (for example, when they browse to `http://localhost/search`). To do this, you need to add a new route handler.

6. Open `main.js` (which you can find in the `routes` folder). Add the following route handler:

```
router.get("/search", (req, res) => {
  res.render("search.ejs")
});
```

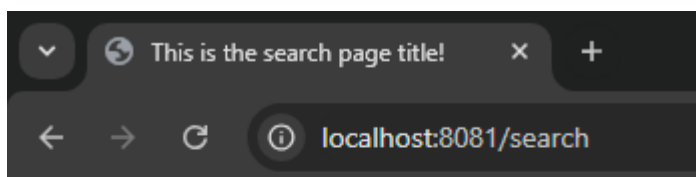
Task 4: Run the code

7. Run the `index.js` file with the following Terminal command:

```
node index.js
```

The above command will start a web server running on port 8081.

You should see the search page, with the search form.



This is the search page

End of lab

Congratulations on completing this lab.

You have successfully created a web application that serves html files containing forms. You may be wondering how you can retrieve the search keyword entered by the user of your web application and use it to search for relevant content. We will come back to this question in future lab activities.